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The Sibling Conflict Scripts

Forty scripts for the most common sibling fights. The "she's touching me" loop. The "it's not fair" pile-on. The toy that suddenly matters because the sibling wants it. The bedtime hour. Plus a parent guide on what NOT to do (no judging-who-started-it, no forced apologies, no "you're the older one" assignment).

Soothemade **Notes**

A SMALL APOTHECARY OF PRINTABLES · MADE SLOWLY

A note before you print

The fights between siblings are not, mostly, about the toy. The fights are about which kid feels seen this hour, which kid is hungry, which kid is over-tired, and which kid noticed first that the other one is allowed to do something they aren't.

The scripts in this deck do not solve the fights. They give you, the adult, something to say in the middle of one. Things that do not require you to figure out who started it, do not require you to issue judgment, and do not require you to be a calmer person than you actually are at this hour.

These work best when used repeatedly. The first time you say "I'm not refereeing this one, you two figure it out," it will sound strange to everyone, including you. The tenth time, it will sound normal. The thirtieth time, the kids will start figuring it out before you say anything.

With care, Maya

How to use these scripts

- Print on cardstock. Cut along the lines. Each card about playing-card sized.
- Punch a hole in one corner. Put the deck on a binder ring.
- Keep one deck in the car. One in the kitchen. One in your bag.
- Read the scripts out loud, in a calm room, once. The body learns them.
- Use the actual cards in the moment if your brain is offline. Just read one aloud.
- Bedtime works best for practicing. Read the scripts when both kids are asleep, on a quiet evening, with a partner if you have one.

What the scripts are designed to do

Three things:

1. **Take you out of the referee role.** You are not the judge of who started it. You will be wrong as often as right, and the kid who is found "guilty" will spend the next decade believing they are the bad sibling.
2. **Give the kids a way to exit the conflict without losing face.** Kids in a fight need an escape ramp. The scripts often provide one.
3. **Lower your own activation.** Saying a script (even one you are not sure works) gets you out of the "I am about to lose it" mode and into "I am performing a known sequence."

The scripts will not stop the fights. Fighting between siblings is normal, healthy, and developmentally important. The scripts make the fights end faster, lower the intensity, and shift over time toward kids resolving things themselves.

Card pack one, the “she’s touching me” loop (10 scripts)

The fights about physical space. The car. The couch. The doorway.

1.

“I’m not refereeing this one. You two have until I count to thirty to figure out where each of you goes.”

(Then count, out loud, slowly. By twenty, they have usually found a configuration. If they haven’t, see card 2.)

2.

“Okay. I’m going to assign seats. You both don’t get to be mad at me, because I gave you a chance to do it yourselves.”

(Then assign. Don’t negotiate.)

3.

“In our family, bodies belong to their own people. I’m going to ask you to give your sister back her [foot / arm / shoulder].”

4.

“You don’t have to like each other right this minute. You do have to not touch each other right this minute.”

5.

"The couch has a left side and a right side and a middle. You each get one side. I get the middle if you can't figure it out."

(Then sit in the middle. It works.)

6.

"You are allowed to ask your sibling to stop. You are not allowed to push. Both are real rules."

7.

"Heads up: every time you say 'she's touching me' I'm going to start counting. At ten, you switch seats. You can call it earlier if you want."

8.

"I notice that the touching gets worse when you are both hungry. We are stopping for a snack."

(Often the real fix is a snack. Always carry one.)

9.

"I'm putting on a song. By the time it's over, you two will have figured this out, or I will."

(The song is the structure. Three minutes is enough.)

10.

"This is the third time today. Let's just acknowledge: today is a hard day for the two of you. That's information, not a problem. What would help?"

Card pack two, the “it’s not fair” pile-on (10 scripts)

When the older one has decided the universe is rigged. When the younger one has decided the older one gets everything. When both are sometimes right.

1.

“You’re right. It isn’t fair. Fair isn’t always possible. Let’s talk about what we can do about THIS specific thing, not all-the-fair in the world.”

2.

“Different doesn’t mean unfair. You two are different ages. Different ages get different things. The two-year-old also doesn’t have to make the bed.”

3.

“You’ll get a turn when you are five, just like she did. The not-yet is real. The not-yet doesn’t mean never.”

4.

“In our family, we don’t keep score. The scoreboard is exhausting for me too.”

5.

“I see that you are upset about _____. Let me hear the whole sentence about why.”

(Then listen. Often there is a real grievance underneath the surface grievance.)

6.

"You're not asking for fair. You're asking for more. Both are real feelings. We can talk about more."

7.

"I'm going to say no. You can be upset about the no. The no will still be no. We can be sad about that together."

8.

"Tell me one thing you got today that your sibling did NOT get."

(Often surprising. Often resets the conversation.)

9.

"I see that you noticed your sibling got something you wanted. Noticing is okay. The next move is yours: you can ask, you can wait, or you can stay mad. I'm not going to make the choice for you."

10.

"Today is one of the days where the unfair-feeling is bigger than it usually is. I'm not going to argue with the feeling. Want a hug? Want to be alone? Want me to make a snack?"

Card pack three, the toy/object fights (10 scripts)

The toy nobody played with for six months that suddenly is the only thing that matters.

1.

"The toy is now in time-out. It will come back in ten minutes. Find something else."

(Set a real timer. The toy comes back. The kids will have moved on by then.)

2.

"It looks like both of you suddenly need this toy. I'm going to hold it. Tell me, each of you, what you wanted to do with it."

(Often one of them just wanted to know they could have it. The asking is the work.)

3.

"In this family, when one person is playing with a thing, the other person waits. They can ask for a turn. They cannot grab."

4.

"Your sister had it first. That's how the rule goes. You can ask politely. The answer might still be no."

5.

"I'm setting a 5-minute timer. When it goes off, the toy goes from her to you. After 5 more minutes, it goes back. The two of you can keep doing that until you both lose interest."

(Highly effective. Kids almost always lose interest before the first cycle.)

6.

"This is a toy. Toys are for play. We do not lose friends over toys. I'm going to remind you of that and then move on."

7.

"You're allowed to want it. You're not allowed to grab it. Wanting and grabbing are two different things."

8.

"Both of you, hands behind your back. Now look at the toy. Now look at me. Now let's talk about this without grabbing."

9.

"This toy is causing too much trouble today. It is going to live up high until tomorrow. We can try again then."

10.

"It is your toy. It is also her sibling. Both of those are facts. You get to decide which one matters more, this hour."

Card pack four, the bedtime hour fights (10 scripts)

When everyone is depleted. The routines fall apart. The question “who is sleeping where” becomes a 40-minute negotiation.

1.

“Bedtime is bedtime. The fighting is not changing the bedtime. It is just making it harder.”

2.

“In our family, the older one does NOT have to put the younger one to bed. That is not your job. That is my job.”

3.

“You don’t have to fall asleep. You do have to be quiet in your bed. I’ll check on you in fifteen minutes.”

4.

“I see that you don’t want to be apart from your sibling. We have a rule about that, which is the bedrooms are separate. You can wave goodnight.”

5.

“The fight you are having about who-gets-the-bath-first is a stalling tactic and I love that you are trying. But it is bath time. Older one goes first tonight, younger one tomorrow.”

(Pre-decide. Don’t ask.)

6.

"I'm going to read one book to both of you, and then you go to your own rooms. Pick the book together. You have one minute to decide."

7.

"I see one of you crying and one of you walking away. Both of those are okay right now. We are all going to bed."

8.

"The thing you are fighting about is not the real reason. The real reason is that you are tired. I'm tired too. Let's all be tired together and not say any more sentences."

9.

"In our family, the last twenty minutes of the day are a slow zone. I'm not going to negotiate or referee. Whatever happens in the slow zone, happens. Tomorrow is a new day."

10.

"Goodnight. I love you. I love both of you. I will see you in the morning."

(Then you walk out. Even if they are still talking. Especially if they are still talking.)

What NOT to say

A page. The phrases that almost universally backfire.

“Who started it?”

You will be wrong half the time. The kid you label as “the starter” will spend years believing they are the bad sibling. The other kid will spend years using the moment as ammunition. Skip the question.

A substitute:

"I don't actually need to know who started it. I need both of you to stop."

“You’re the older one, you should know better.”

This is a sentence that, accumulated, builds resentment. The older one did not choose to be older. The expectation that they hold the responsibility of being the calmer one ages them prematurely.

A substitute:

"You're both still figuring this out. I'm asking both of you to take a breath."

“Apologize to your sister.”

A forced apology is not an apology. The kid says “sorry” with no meaning. The kid receiving it does not feel repaired. The next fight starts.

A substitute:

"I see that something hurt. Take a minute. When you're ready, see if you can say what you wish you had done differently. If you're not ready, you don't have to do it now."

"If you don't stop fighting, you're both in trouble."

The "both in trouble" approach feels fair to the adult and feels insanely unfair to whichever kid believes themselves wronged. It also creates an alliance between them against you (sometimes useful, often not).

A substitute:

"I'm going to walk away for two minutes. When I come back, I want to see two people figuring out where to go from here. If you can't, I'll help."

"Why can't you just be nice to each other?"

A rhetorical question that doesn't have an answer. They cannot, because they are 4 and 7 and they are still learning what nice even is.

A substitute:

"Today is hard. You two will figure this out over time. Today, I just need both of you safe."

A page on the underlying pattern

A page to read when calm. Not while a fight is happening.

Most sibling fights, when you look at them across a week or a month, are not random. They cluster.

Common patterns:

- **Right before meals.** Hungry kids fight. Snacks before the next “they were just at the table” hour.
- **Right after meals.** Some kids fight when they are tired and full. Quiet time after lunch.
- **In the car.** Confined space. Limited stimulation. They fight because there is nothing else. Audiobooks help.
- **The first 20 minutes after one parent comes home.** Reunion is a transition. Kids dysregulate at transitions.
- **When one parent is unavailable.** Each kid is competing for the available adult. Have a “one kid gets you for ten minutes, then the other” approach.
- **When a new sibling is announced or arrives.** Months of friction.
- **At handoffs (daycare drop-off, bedtime, etc.).** Transitions again.
- **When a kid is overstimulated.** Often after a busy day. Quiet, dim, fewer choices.
- **When a kid is under-stimulated.** A long quiet afternoon with nothing to do.

Once you see the pattern, you can do less refereeing and more upstream work. Snack. Quiet. A walk. A separate-rooms hour.

When to step in, when to step back

A simple decision tree.

THE FIGHT IS:

- A) Verbal (words, tones, "I'm telling Mom")
 - Step BACK. Let them work it out. Be in the next room, available.
 - B) Verbal escalating to crying
 - Step into the room. Don't intervene yet. Just be present. Often your presence alone settles it.
 - C) One kid is being mean (taunting, name-calling, "you never get anything because Mom likes me better")
 - Step in. Name the behavior. "That sentence was a hurtful one. We don't do that in our family."
 - Do not require an apology. Do require a stop.
 - D) Physical contact (pushing, grabbing, holding)
 - Step in. Physically separate. Voice calm.
 - "I'm moving you both. We are not negotiating this part."
 - E) Hitting, biting, kicking, or anything that could leave a mark
 - Stop everything. Move the aggressor away to a safe location. Stay with the hurt one. Check the body. Repair later.
 - F) One kid is afraid of the other
 - This is a different conversation. Separate the kids fully. Talk with each one alone. May warrant a real provider conversation, especially if it's ongoing.
-

The repair, after

Repair is more important than perfection. Repair is also the thing kids actually learn from.

After the fight

When everyone is calm. Not in the moment. Sometime in the next two hours.

"Earlier you two had a hard time with each other. Want to talk about what happened?"

(Then listen. Don't pre-judge. Let them tell you what they think happened.)

"That sounds hard. What was the hardest part?"

(Listen more. Often surprises you. Often the hardest part wasn't the moment you thought it was.)

"What would help, next time something like this comes up?"

(Don't expect a brilliant answer. Often "I don't know."
That is fine. The question itself is the lesson.)

When YOU lost it

Adult repair is the biggest single thing you can do. The kids will model it.

"Earlier, when you two were fighting, I yelled. I shouldn't have. The fighting was not okay, but my yelling was also not okay. I'm sorry."

"I'm working on this too. We are all practicing."

The kids will hear this. They will copy it. Months later, you will hear one of them say it to the other. That is the work.

A note for two-kid households

The dynamic between two kids is its own organism. By age seven or so, most siblings will have a specific dance. Recognize it. Some of it is fine. Some is a pattern worth interrupting.

Common patterns:

- **The one who provokes / the one who reacts.** Often shifts between them across years. The “provoker” sometimes does it for connection. The “reactor” sometimes uses the reaction to get adult attention. Both are real.
- **The kid who tattles / the kid who pretends not to hear.** The tattler is often genuinely uncertain whether the other behavior is allowed. Not always trying to get the other kid in trouble.
- **The “older one is responsible for the younger” trap.** Many families fall into this. Resist. The older one is not the parent.
- **The “younger one gets away with everything” pattern.** Often true. Often necessary at the younger one’s age. Older one’s grievance is real.

A note for three-or-more-kid households

The math changes. With three, you have three pairs of relationships at any moment. With four, six pairs.

The pack still works. Use them on whichever pair is currently in conflict. Try not to manage all the pairs at once.

THE CURRENT FIGHTING PAIR

Tonight's pair (or this hour's):

_____ and _____

The third (and fourth) kid right now:

_____ is doing: _____

_____ is doing: _____

The script I'm going to try first:

What's normal and what's worth a real provider

A short page. Honest.

Normal sibling conflict:

- Frequent (multiple times a day, especially under age 6)
- Verbal escalation
- Occasional physical (a shove, a snatched toy)
- Quick resolution (with or without adult)
- Affectionate moments still present
- One or both kids using the conflict to get adult attention

Worth talking to a pediatric provider or family therapist:

- One kid is consistently afraid of the other
- One kid has started hurting the other in a way that leaves marks
- A kid has started destroying the other's things
- A kid has started taking pleasure in the other's pain (not occasional, sustained)
- The intensity of fights is escalating, not steady
- A kid is showing signs of trauma (sleep changes, withdrawal, regression) tied to the sibling relationship
- The household pattern is starting to mirror an unhealthy adult dynamic

If anything on the second list resonates, please talk to a real provider. The pediatrician is a fine starting point. They will know local family therapists.

Numbers to keep

PEDIATRICIAN

Name: _____ Number: _____

FAMILY THERAPIST (if relevant)

Name: _____ Number: _____

SCHOOL COUNSELOR (if relevant)

Name: _____ Number: _____

US CHILDHELP NATIONAL HOTLINE

1-800-422-4453 (24/7, free, confidential, for parents
struggling with parenting)

US MATERNAL MENTAL HEALTH HOTLINE

1-833-852-6262 (24/7, free, confidential)



From *Soothemade Notes*, a small apothecary of printables, planners, and cards for the unphotographed parts of new parenthood. Made slowly, in plain language.



Soothemade *Notes*

*Made for the version of you no one tells you about, the
one at four in the morning, the one in the parking lot, the
one who doesn't recognize her own week.*

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